AI PRODUCT MANAGEMENT 2 · DETAILED COURSE

Product Leadership and Stakeholder Management

The people skills that turn good plans into shipped results: influence, communication and decision-making.

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CHAPTER 22

Product Leadership and Stakeholder Management

The people skills that turn good plans into shipped results: influence, communication and decision-making.

Product Leadership Fundamentals

Setting direction, building clarity and accountability, and growing others while keeping the product outcome in view.

Product leaders set direction, build clarity and accountability, and grow others while keeping the customer outcome in view. Leadership is measured by what the team can do without the leader.

Stakeholder Mapping

Listing stakeholders by influence and interest to decide how to engage each.

List stakeholders by influence and interest, then decide how to engage each. An executive with high influence and low interest needs short, decision-focused updates.

Stakeholder Communication

Tailored, regular updates that state decisions, risks and asks clearly.

Tailored, regular updates state decisions, risks and requests clearly. Stakeholders trust a PM who reports bad news early.

Influence Without Authority

Gaining support through evidence, relationships, shared goals and understanding others' incentives.

Gain support through evidence, relationships, shared goals and understanding of others' incentives. Most PM work happens without direct authority over the people involved.

Cross-Functional Leadership

Aligning product, engineering, design, data, sales and operations on one outcome.

Align product, engineering, design, data, sales and operations on one outcome. Shared goals and a common view of the data reduce conflict.

Engineering Collaboration

Involving engineers early, respecting constraints and agreeing trade-offs on scope and quality.

Involve engineers early, respect constraints, and agree trade-offs on scope and quality together. An engineer's estimate of risk is valuable input, not an obstacle.

Design Collaboration

Co-owning the problem with designers, sharing research and critiquing work against goals.

Co-own the problem with designers, share research and critique work against goals rather than taste. Good critique asks what the user is trying to do.

Data Science Collaboration

Framing the problem, agreeing success metrics and evaluation, and understanding model limits together.

Frame the problem together, agree success metrics and evaluation, and share an understanding of model limits. Data scientists know what the data can and cannot support.

Executive Communication

Lead with the conclusion, give the numbers and the decision needed, and keep it short.

Lead with the conclusion, give the key numbers and state the decision needed. Keep it short, and prepare for the question you least want to be asked.

Product Presentations

Structure around the audience's question: context, insight, recommendation and next steps.

Structure the talk around the audience's question: context, insight, recommendation and next steps. Show the evidence behind each claim.

Negotiation

Reaching agreements by understanding interests, creating options and trading what each side values.

Reach agreement by understanding interests, creating options and trading what each side values less for what it values more. Negotiate scope and date together, not separately.

Conflict Resolution

Surfacing the real disagreement, using shared facts and focusing on the goal.

Surface the real disagreement, use shared facts and refocus on the goal. Most product conflicts are about different assumptions about the user.

Decision-Making

Clear owner, defined criteria, enough evidence for the risk, and a record of the decision.

A good decision has a clear owner, defined criteria, enough evidence for the risk involved and a written record. Decide at the lowest level that has the information needed.

Product Reviews

Scheduled reviews of progress, metrics and risks with leadership.

Scheduled reviews of progress, metrics and risks with leadership. Bring the metrics, what changed, what you learned and what you need.

Product Governance

Standards and forums that guide what is built, approved and retired.

Standards and forums that guide what is built, approved and retired. Good governance speeds decisions by making rules clear in advance.

Managing Product Teams

Hiring, coaching, setting expectations and giving feedback to PMs.

Hire, coach, set expectations and give feedback to PMs. Give feedback close to the event and focus on behaviour and outcome.

Strategic Alignment

Making sure team goals connect to company strategy and to each other.

Make sure team goals connect to company strategy and to each other. Check alignment by asking teams to explain the company goal in their own words.

Product Culture

Shared habits of curiosity, customer focus, evidence and accountability.

Shared habits of curiosity, customer focus, evidence and accountability. Culture shows in what teams do when no one is watching, such as how they handle a failed launch.

Summary of terms

Term	Meaning
Product Leadership Fundamentals	Setting direction, building clarity and accountability, and growing others while keeping the product outcome in view.
Stakeholder Mapping	Listing stakeholders by influence and interest to decide how to engage each.
Stakeholder Communication	Tailored, regular updates that state decisions, risks and asks clearly.
Influence Without Authority	Gaining support through evidence, relationships, shared goals and understanding others' incentives.
Cross-Functional Leadership	Aligning product, engineering, design, data, sales and operations on one outcome.
Engineering Collaboration	Involving engineers early, respecting constraints and agreeing trade-offs on scope and quality.
Design Collaboration	Co-owning the problem with designers, sharing research and critiquing work against goals.

Data Science Collaboration	Framing the problem, agreeing success metrics and evaluation, and understanding model limits together.
Executive Communication	Lead with the conclusion, give the numbers and the decision needed, and keep it short.
Product Presentations	Structure around the audience's question: context, insight, recommendation and next steps.
Negotiation	Reaching agreements by understanding interests, creating options and trading what each side values.
Conflict Resolution	Surfacing the real disagreement, using shared facts and focusing on the goal.
Decision-Making	Clear owner, defined criteria, enough evidence for the risk, and a record of the decision.
Product Reviews	Scheduled reviews of progress, metrics and risks with leadership.
Product Governance	Standards and forums that guide what is built, approved and retired.
Managing Product Teams	Hiring, coaching, setting expectations and giving feedback to PMs.
Strategic Alignment	Making sure team goals connect to company strategy and to each other.
Product Culture	Shared habits of curiosity, customer focus, evidence and accountability.

Practice exercise: Map stakeholders for a launch, then write the executive update: decision needed, recommendation, risks, and next steps in under 200 words.

Self-check

1. Explain Product Leadership Fundamentals in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.
2. Explain Product Presentations in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.
3. Explain Product Culture in two sentences to a non-technical stakeholder, then say what you would measure for it.

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